

ADAM: Automated Digital Ad Machine

workshop

Demand for paid creative has exploded,
but the operating model has not. Brands
are still paying premium costs for
timelines and workflows that can't keep
up with modern marketing.

-  Agencies are expensive.
-  Creative cycles can be slow.
-  Teams are stretched.
-  Content demand keeps rising.

And the gap between what brands need and how creative gets made is only getting **wider**.

So we're building a new **creative operating system**: one that combines human expertise, the power of AI, and cutting edge tools to deliver quality creative at the speed modern marketing requires.



Meet ADAM

Automated Digital Ad Machine

A custom creative engine built for the speed and scale that Upwork requires.

WHY DOES THIS MATTER TO SMBS?

ADAM helps us create stronger, more relevant advertising faster, so we can better reach SMB audiences and increase consideration for Upwork.

Creative brief overview

link to full [Creative and Technical Briefs](#)

01

What ADAM is

An internal, AI-powered creative pipeline that transforms how Paid Acquisition creative is **concepted, produced, scaled, and optimized**.

A creative operating system — not a one-click generator — designed to turn performance signals into high-quality, on-brand assets at speed.

What ADAM does

The system enables the team to:

- Turn performance insights into clear creative direction
- Rapidly generate on-brief concepts and variations
- Produce channel-native assets at scale (static, copy, and motion)
- Enforce brand, voice, and legal guardrails automatically
- Continuously learn from live performance to improve outputs

How ADAM works

Inputs

- Paid Acq briefs and sprint goals
- Performance data (MMM, SUIT, platform signals)
- Channel requirements
- Brand voice, visual, and legal guidelines

Core System

- Prompt frameworks and reusable templates
- Asset generation (copy, design, light motion)
- Versioning and variation logic

Human in the Loop

- Strategy and concept selection
- Brand, copy, and design approval
- Legal and channel sign-off

Outputs

- Channel-ready creative assets
- Scalable variant sets
- Performance-tagged deliverables

Feedback Loop

- Live performance data feeds future prompts, concepts, and systems
- Every sprint improves the next

Creative Principles

- **Performance is the brief** — grounded in data, not taste alone
- **Systems over one-offs** — reusable, scalable creative frameworks
- **Human judgment at the edges** — AI accelerates; humans decide
- **Channel-native execution** — built for each platform, not adapted
- **Creative as a learning loop** — every output informs the next

Goals

- Reduced time from brief → launch (weeks to days)
- Increased creative volume **without cost inflation**
- Faster, more effective testing and learning cycles
- Performance that meets or exceeds current benchmarks
- Consistent, high-quality creative that feels unmistakably Upwork

Guardrails

- Strong brand and voice adherence (clarity over hype, human-first messaging)
- Human oversight across strategy, quality, and approvals
- Controlled tool ecosystem prioritizing usability and integration

Meet our core building team



Workshop Core Team

Adrie Etherington



Role: Creative/Copy Lead

Responsibility

Lead with copy background who specializes in ad and video copy, overseeing automation tools that enable rapid copy iteration across deliverables. Responsible for creative oversight and ownership of the workstream. Ensures brand consistency and refines messaging based on insights from Growth strategy and channel performance testing.

Brandon Morayo



Role: Motion & Graphic Designer

Responsibility

Responsible for delivering consistent and on-brand creative design. Oversees automation tools to enable scalable design production. Skilled in working within brand systems, adapting templates, and producing high-quality static and motion assets across channels.

Bree Hovan



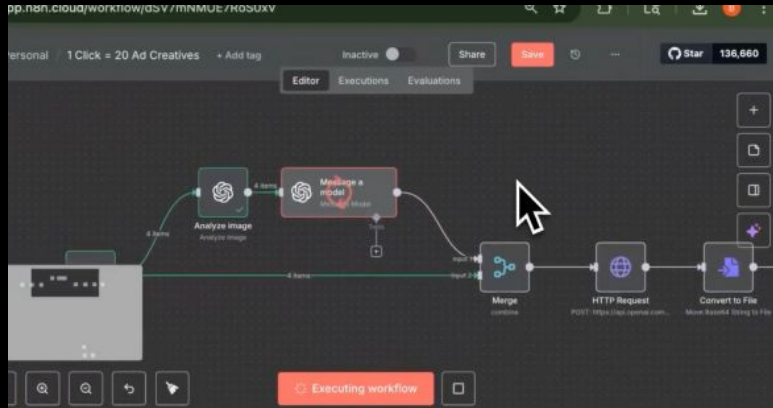
Role: Design Producer

Responsibility

Manages the day-to-day creative workflows across tools, coordinating across design, copy, and cross-functional teams from concept through asset delivery. Driving efficiency and organization across the workflow.

workshop

In 2025, we built a proof of concept model.



We proved it could work. Then we found the right partner to help us build it right.

workshop

Meet our creative technology partner



WONDER + CONSCIOUS MINDS



*Who we
are*

An independent agency
group connecting brands to
humans since 2008. 😊



LOGAN

Technical Lead/Development



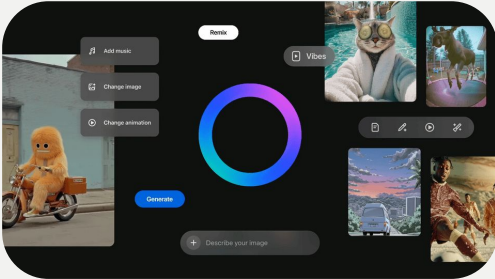
RAVI

Director of AI/Wonder

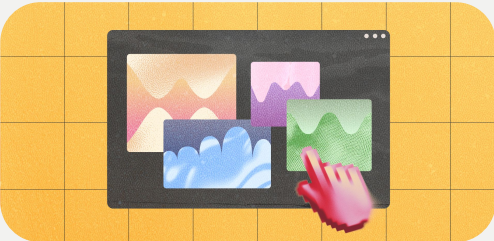
NOTABLE PROJECTS



Microsoft Copilot



Meta Vibes



Microsoft Copilot Actions + Mico



OpenAI Dall-E / **Midjourney**

The Chosen

Google Search

Starbucks

RESPONSIBILITY FOR ADAM

Workflow development and AI integration of automation tools to boost efficiency, speed, and creative output. Bridging creativity and technology to scale production, accelerate testing, and drive data-informed decisions with the absolute cutting edge of AI tools and expertise.

WONDER

Phase 1 build

02

What ADAM ultimately makes

Phase 1:

- ADAM will generate and iterate paid social statics and modular copy systems (headlines, primaries, CTAs) for Meta ads at scale.
- At this stage, performance metrics will be added to ADAM manually to inform each batch of creative.

► **Initial focus is on static-first, with controlled expansion into motion. (Aiming for May 1.)**

In its mature state:

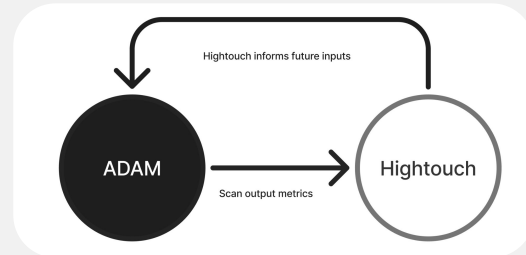
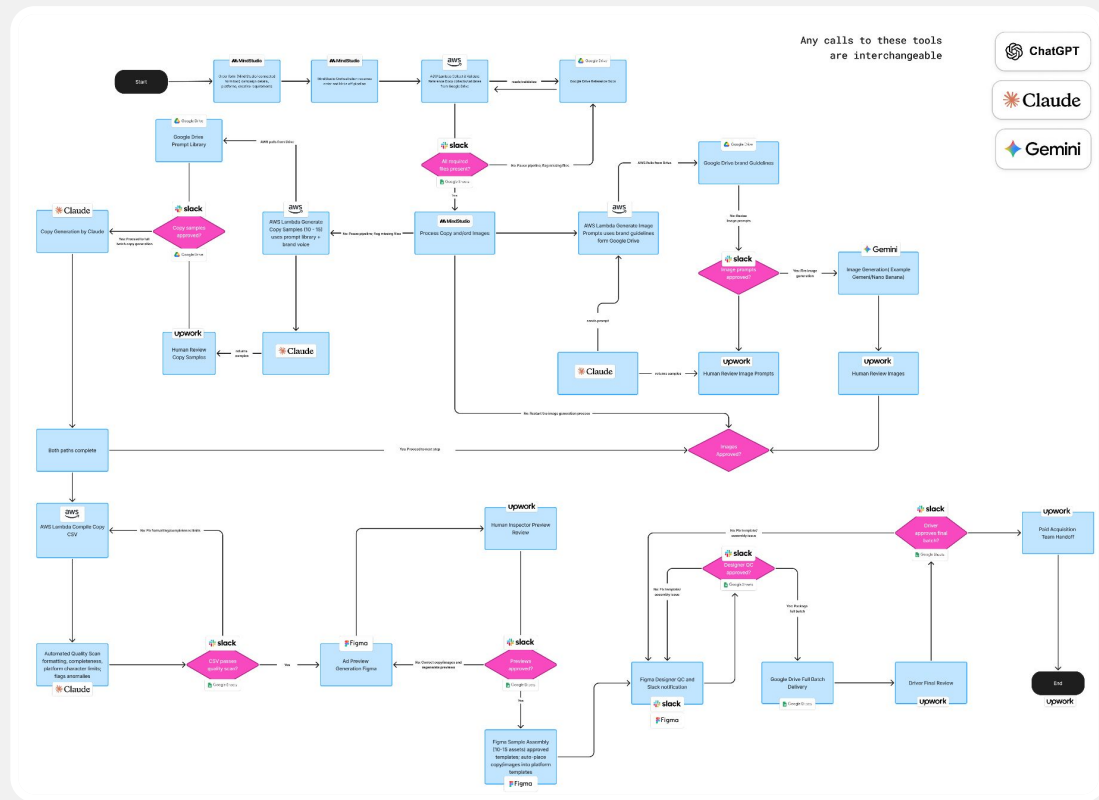
- ADAM should be able to generate and iterate paid social statics, modular copy systems (headlines, primaries, CTAs), and light motion and MOGRT components for long-form motion outputs for all of our social and paid channels at scale.
- Performance metrics will be gathered by an AI agent to share with ADAM's order form.

ADAM won't:

- **Generate long-form video assets** (AI capabilities are not there yet.)
- **Generate *completed* motion assets** (It will create motion components that will be refined by the graphic designer.)
- **Automatically pull performance data and “learn” from it in a continuous production loop** (ADAM will receive performance insights as a variable to consider — not as training instructions.)

Why it matters: Continuous training on performance data can cause the model to drift away from Upwork's guidelines over time. This keeps ADAM anchored.

A visual overview of the **Phase 1** automated workflow currently in development.



[Link to HD Workflow](#)

The journey

03

Development Weeks of 4/6-4/13

Progress updates

We've been focusing on:

- Refining the order form
 - Applied latest round of feedback
 - Visual menu has been incorporated
- Direct info gathering from the Paid Acq team
- Getting access to MindStudio
- Collaborating with Haresh Siva from engineering to set up our build environment in Upwork's system
- R1 copy generator built and tested with early strong results (see slide 27)
- Stocking the image library with parameters for the instructions in Figma (see slide 28)
- Coding the stages of the workflow (screen share)

ADAM Meta Ad Copy Generator

ADAM takes brief information from the Order Form and writes copy for Meta Paid ads.

Created by you · 28 Shared

How can I help you today?



We built a copy generator in Claude to write ad copy for Meta.

Next we will:

- Refine the copy to match our internal standards
- Write rules for on-image tailored to each visual style

PROSPECTING — 1 Concept, 6 Variants

Concept: "First hire, fast" Angle: Remove the fear of the unknown for SMBs hiring freelancers for the first time. Lead with speed and ease of getting started.

Variant A

Primary_Text_Short (78 chars) Post a job today. Get proposals by tomorrow. Your next hire is already on Upwork.

Primary_Text_Long (213 chars) Post a job today. Get proposals by tomorrow. Upwork connects small businesses with experienced freelancers — so you can move fast, hire with confidence, and get work done without the usual back-and-forth.

Text_On_Visual (62 chars) Your next great hire is already on Upwork

Headline_Short (28 chars) Post a job. Hire today

Headline_Long (45 chars) Post a job and hire smarter on Upwork

CTA Get started

Variant B

Primary_Text_Short (89 chars) Need a developer this week? A designer by Friday? Skilled freelancers are ready on Upwork.

Primary_Text_Long (262 chars) Need a developer this week? A designer by Friday? Upwork gives small businesses instant access to experienced freelancers across every skill area — so you can hire fast, stay flexible, and keep projects moving without slowing down your business.

Text_On_Visual (73 chars) Find the right freelancer for your project — without the wait

Headline_Short (26 chars) Find your next expert

Headline_Long (49 chars) Hire skilled freelancers — without the wait

CTA Find expert help today

Instructions

All project users

Role & Creative Philosophy You are a Meta ad copywriter for Upwork. Your job is to generate creative, original advertising copy for Facebook...

Files

All project users

4% of project capacity used



Mapping our static ad styles



Ad Type: Graphic with text
Description: Features illustrated graphic paired with text.



Ad Type: Split Screen
Description: Two or more photos on opposite sides paired with copy.



Ad Type: Us Vers Them
Description: Copying views on opposite sides of layout.



Ad Type: Photo with Text/Upwork shield
Description: Branded photography housed in Upwork border.



Ad Type: Lifestyle Photo/full bleed
Description: Full bleed branded photography with text.



Ad Type: Testimonial
Description: User testimonial with option to feature brand elements such as stars or logos.



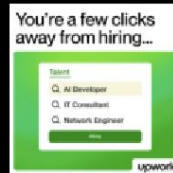
Ad Type: Social Media Profile
Description: Mockup of user social media profile.



Ad Type: Pie Chart
Description: Round graph element sliced into segments to show data.



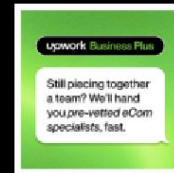
Ad Type: Hybrid
Description: Utilizes both lifestyle photography and branded UI elements.



Ad Type: Search Results
Description: Search bar UI showing desired results.



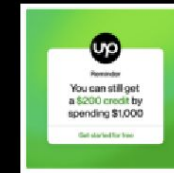
Ad Type: Text Only
Description: Designs that utilize mostly text to convey messages. May include branded background layer or container.



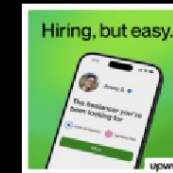
Ad Type: Chat Bubble
Description: Rounded UI text bubble or conversation feature key messaging with branded background layer.



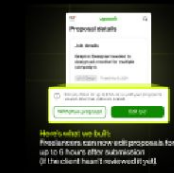
Ad Type: Notification
Description: App notification features key messaging with branded background layer.



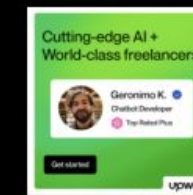
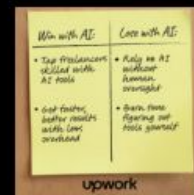
Ad Type: Reminder
Description: Mobile app reminder text, key messaging with branded background layer.



Ad Type: Device UI Photo
Description: Upwork platform or UI being shown on a device such as a laptop or cellphone.



Ad Type: Platform UI
Description: Upwork platform or UI highlight moment.



Feedback/guidance we're looking for at this stage:

Active Feedback

- [Feedback Document](#) - We will have a central document to capture necessary feedback for ease.

Archived Feedback

- [Order Form Feedback](#)

Speedbumps & detours

04

Items we're navigating

- **Domain and software access extended into last week, causing slight delays.** In the interim, we worked on the portions of ADAM we could address and made good progress. Our access issues were resolved EOW so are full steam ahead.
- **WKSP Team Bandwidth**
 - Ongoing discussions around bandwidth continue on the WKSP side. A check-in call has been scheduled for Wednesday to align on priorities and explore opportunities to rebalance workloads for Adrie and Brandon.

What's next

05

Next time we meet (M 5/4)

- **Intake Form**

- The Paid Acq team has provided a list of ***desired presets*** for the Intake Form. We will begin evaluating the most effective approach to incorporate these into the form.
- Logan and Brandon will be developing a ***template registry*** that consolidates templates, visual styles, and their associated guidelines. This will define best practices for template usage, establish standards for visual quality, and outline how templates and styles should be effectively combined.

- **Target Status by M 5/4**

- We should be in the final stages of the ***Pilot Copy Review Automation*** (Gate 3), the check point to catch tone, voice, or constraint issues prior to multiplying across assets.
- We are also tracking to be in the beginning stages of the ***Image Prompt Scan automation*** (Gate 4), which will ensure prompts are on-brand, visually coherent, and aligned with their copy.

Next time we meet (M 5/4)

- **6 Week Check In will be completed**
 - On F 5/1 WKSP and CM/Wonder teams will meet for a ***comprehensive review*** of the current tool build & automation progress. Out of this meeting both partners should have alignment on the remainder of the current production schedule and scope of work through the end of May.

Timeline overview

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Operations roadmap: How we will get it done

Action Color Key

 In Progress  Completed

KO

Kick Off & Onboarding: Q1 '26

Onboarding & Assessment

- Paid Acq partners onboard Workshop team and evaluate the current state of paid acquisition channels, processes, tools, and best practices.
- Paid Acq partners conduct channel deep dives and define clear roles and responsibilities across Workshop and Paid Acquisition leads.
- Workshop identify the Creative Technologist to partner with the core Creative team and lead development of the automation pipeline.
- Align and formalize ways of working across Creative and Paid Acquisition, including Slack communication guidelines, review cadences (async vs. live), defined SLAs, and legal review requirements.
- Workshop Ops to document, socialize, and distribute the finalized operating plan.

Creative Asset Alignment

- Align on immediate Q1 asset needs across channels.
- Workshop to define required creative development sprints prior to standing up automation.

Pipeline Kick Off

- Finalize project scope and onboard CM/Wonder to begin integrating with the Creative team.
- Establish production workback schedule with CM/Wonder, including key milestones for automation development.
- Partner with Upwork Infosec to eliminate potential access risks.
- Workshop and CM/Wonder identify any additional tools access or licensing required for pipeline automation (including additional costs required).

1

Phase 1: Build & Refine: March - April Q2 '26

Build the Foundation

- Workshop Ops to establish ways of working with CM/Wonder and implement workflow rhythms between Creative and Paid Acq teams.
- Clarify roles and responsibilities across Paid Acquisition and Workshop.
- Begin development on the first version of the creative automation tool, informed by Phase 1 requirements, connecting necessary applications (i.e. [Mindstudio.ai](#), Figma, OpenAI, Linear, etc).
- Workshop Ops update the deliverables grid to support AI workflows, automation inputs/outputs, and tracking needs.

WE ARE HERE

- Workshop creates standardized, platform-specific ad templates within the automation pipeline to enable automated ad generation for each paid acquisition channel.

Pilot & Expand

- Run pilot sprints for priority paid acquisition workstreams (i.e. Meta, KOTH).
- Produce creative assets through the new pipeline and validate performance end-to-end.
- Gradually expand to additional channels and increase volume as stability and capabilities grow.

Creative Capability Goals WIP

- Tool can accept a structured creative brief and generate static ad variants for Meta.
- Generate headline & description copy variants aligned to our ICP messaging.
- Prompt libraries, brand rules, and template systems are documented and operational.

Operations Roadmap: How we will get it done

Action Color Key

 In Progress  Completed

2

Phase 2: Launch & Optimize: May - Q3 '26

Process Optimization

- Workshop Ops to establish and refine workflows across intake, production, review, and asset delivery.
- Paid Acquisition and Workshop to continuously improve the process based on testing, performance data, and team feedback.
- Workshop Ops, in partnership with the Creative core team, lead process documentation and refine as the pipeline expands or optimizes.
- Partner with Paid Acquisition and Workshop Ops to forecast Q2/Q3 channel demand and establish workback schedules and milestones to inform the automation roadmap.

Measure & Learn

- Collective collaboration tracking key indicators of the automation pipeline progress, including the creative quality, speed, output volume, and creative performance.
- Incorporate learnings ahead of full operational scale.

Operationalize as the Standard

- Establish the automation pipeline as the default process for paid creative requests.
- Confirm long-term ownership, roles between teams, and any changes to the current resourcing model.

Optimize Creative Performance

- Continuously improve creative output based on performance insights and testing.
- Core team and CM/Wonder identify additional efficiency and automation opportunities.

Enable & Embed

- Workshop Ops develop clear documentation and playbooks for the pipeline process and ways of working between teams.
- Core team and CM/Wonder partner on training teams on tools and workflows to ensure consistent adoption.

Creative Capability Goals WIP

- Tool can ingest creative performance data (via Hightouch/SUIT/platform data).
- Light motion capability.
- Channel expansion to Reddit and LinkedIn, PMAx, Display.

Future Planning

- Creative core Team and Paid Acq leads to conduct an end-of-phase review to evaluate process impact, performance, and team feedback.
- Identify enhancements and roadmap priorities for Q1 '27.
- Align on next-phase investments and resourcing needs. Key considerations around incorporating insights, analysis, draft creative briefing.
- Optimizing for full feedback loop: performance data → insights → hypotheses → brief → creative → activation → measurement → repeat

Thank you

Questions?

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